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THE MYTHS OF ORIGIN OF THE INDIAN UNTOUCHABLES

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The world-view of today's untouchables has undoubtedly been influenced by the democratic changes in Indian society. What is less clear, however, is whether untouchables were closer to Hindu orthodoxy and referred to religious concepts to legitimize their inferior position in the past, as Weber has argued. Untouchable myths of origin, the antiquity of which is well established, can be taken as a good illustration of the way untouchables view – and viewed – themselves and their place in society. The myth of origin widely held by untouchables throughout India claims that untouchables were originally respectable people whose present condition is the result of a misunderstanding, rather than of some inherent defect. The myth thus contests the position of untouchables within the caste system, though not the system itself, whose ideological foundations it continues to uphold. This ambiguity is typical of the position of untouchables within Indian society more generally.

Introduction

In one of his famous studies, Max Weber argued that poor and oppressed Indians readily accept their lot, because by so doing they know that their condition will be improved in the next life (1958: 122). Low castes, Weber claimed, perfectly internalize the Brahmanical concepts of *samsaara* (rebirth), *karma* and *dharma*; they are 'tamed by brahmanical theory' (1958: 130) so that they do not revolt against their state of servitude.

Anthropologists are now more cautious about the significance of Sanskritic notions in the Hindu's daily life. It is often reported, for example, that basic Hindu concepts such as *karma* are rarely used by common people, and particularly not by low castes who often do not even know their meaning (Kolenda 1964: 77; Houska 1981: 80). Although the Hindu explanation of life and the world is one of 'the most consistent in History' (Weber 1958: 122), the low castes who are the subject of this article have no clear ideas about the afterlife, and respond to questions on the subject by asking: 'How could we know?' (Deliège 1987: 422; see also Good 1991: 154). Gough reports a similar scepticism among the untouchables of Tanjore district:

One day, sitting in the Adi-Dravida street, I tackled a group of older Pallars on the subjects of death, duty, destiny and rebirth of the soul. In my inadequate Tamil, I asked them where they thought the soul went after death...The group collapsed in merriment – perhaps as much at my speech as at the question. Wiping his eyes, the old man replied, 'Mother, we don't know! Do you know? Have you been there?' I said 'No, but Brahmins say that if people do their

duty well in this life, their souls will be born next time in a higher caste'. 'Brahmans say!' scoffed another elder. 'Brahmans say anything. Their heads go round and round!' (1973: 234).

For over a century, emancipation movements of various sorts – religious, cultural, political (see Joshi 1986) – have undermined Weber's rather gross generalizations. Untouchables today do not believe their condition results from misbehaviour in a former life and they are unwilling to bear oppression in this world in the hope of being reborn 'in the womb of a queen and Brahman's daughter' (Weber 1958: 122). It might be argued that this is largely due to the democratization of Indian society since the nineteenth century, and that the untouchables' world-view was closer to Hindu orthodoxy in the past.

It is obviously impossible to interview untouchables who lived two hundred years ago and there is little historical evidence from this period which might be useful for my purpose. This article suggests, however, that the oral tradition of contemporary untouchables is a privileged means of access to the untouchables' mode of thought. This is particularly true of myths of origin. Myths collected by contemporary ethnographers were already reported in nineteenth-century literature, so that we might reasonably assume them to have a fairly long history. As we shall see, these myths say something about how untouchables view themselves and their place in this world. Such myths are related by untouchables throughout India and they are sufficiently alike to suggest the common expression of similar world-views. Even when the content is slightly different, the structure of the myths remains similar enough to allow one to speak of an 'untouchable myth of origin' (see Deliège 1989: 110). Moreover, the untouchable myths are quite distinct from those of higher and even middle-range castes.

Elsewhere I have emphasized the disagreement between the Paraiyar myth from Tamil Nadu and the Hindu theodicy (Deliège 1989). This earlier analysis questioned Dumont's view that the ideology of hierarchy pervades Hindu social life (see, for instance, Dumont 1966: 268). But my comparison in this article of myths from different parts of India reveals an important fact that brings us closer to Dumont. Although my analysis here confirms that, through their myth, the untouchables contest their position in the caste system, it also shows that they do not question the system itself, which they present as a matter of fact; through their myths, untouchables clearly legitimate the inferior position of those who deal with impure matters, and this brings us back to Dumont. This ambiguity, which I wish to emphasize here, is typical of the untouchables' position in the caste system more generally. To illustrate this ambiguity, I compare untouchable myths from different parts of India, showing that a similar structure underlies them. I begin with the Paraiyar myth, partly because I myself collected it but also partly because it has been discussed by other anthropologists, most notably by Moffatt (1979). First, however, I provide some general background on untouchables and on my field site.

The untouchables of India

In 1991, there were about 140 million untouchables who constituted approximately 15 per cent. of the Indian population. It should be stressed that the term 'untouchables' is rarely used by Indians, including Indian anthropologists, who prefer to refer to them by various euphemisms such as 'Harijans', a word coined

by Gandhi and which means 'the people' (*jan*) of 'God' (*Harī*), or 'Scheduled Castes' – their official name in modern India. The untouchables by no means form a homogeneous category but are divided into hundreds of castes, distributed all over the country. Even within a single region, there are likely to be several untouchable castes which are all strictly endogamous and sometimes quite fastidious about avoiding each other. Untouchables lie at the bottom of Indian society. Economically poor and often living in dire poverty, their inferior position is explained by the permanent ritual impurity deriving from their association with death and organic pollution. They are employed in occupations which are essential for removing impurity from social life, and work as sweepers, scavengers, grave-diggers and tanners. They also work as agricultural labourers and are predominantly landless. Untouchables are socially discriminated against as probably no other people in the world, although the extent of this discrimination varies from region to region. In many places, they cannot enter the streets and houses of the higher castes, nor wear jewellery or fine clothes; more commonly, they are forbidden access to the village wells, and almost everywhere people try to avoid any contact with them. They are despised and are expected to adopt a servile and obsequious attitude when addressing high caste people. They can be beaten by their superiors and formerly could be sold like cattle.

This bleak picture imperfectly reflects today's reality, since untouchables now increasingly assert their rights. Nevertheless, discriminatory attitudes still characterize the lives of most untouchables, albeit to various extents; every day, newspapers report cases of 'atrocities against Harijans', and their economic situation remains very precarious.

Fieldwork was conducted between January 1981 and January 1982 in Valghira Manickam, a village of Ramnad district (Tamil Nadu) inhabited by two of the main untouchable castes in the state, the Paraiyars and the Pallars. Research focused mainly on the former (see Deliège 1988), though a Pallar village 50 km south of Madurai was also studied during a shorter visit in 1989. In Valghira Manickam, two-thirds of the Paraiyars are Roman Catholics and the remainder are Hindus. Villagers mainly work as brickmakers, coolies and agricultural labourers. In Alangkulam, the Pallar village, a considerable number of villagers cultivate small plots of land and work as porters.

I have argued elsewhere that the position of untouchables in Indian society is ambiguous (Deliège 1992: 170). They live on the fringes of society, and act as intermediaries between the human world and the 'wilderness' which surrounds it. Unlike the gypsies, they are not fully marginalized, though neither are they fully part of society. This ambiguity finds expression in their attitude towards the caste system: although they refuse to consider themselves as 'impure', they do not reject the notions of ritual pollution altogether and apply these to the castes below them (Deliège 1992: 166). As we shall see, their myths of origin are probably the clearest expression of this ambiguity.

The Paraiyar myth

I begin with the myths collected in Valghira Manickam. These myths are not central to the Paraiyars in this village and painstaking research was required to unearth them. Some people had never heard of them, others remembered

fragments, though often only the key features of the main myth. Nevertheless, some people referred to these myths as evidence of the unfairness of their low status, and this local usage and interpretation must be taken into account.

A version of the myth collected in Valghira Manickam had already been recorded by Thurston (1909: 84). It is therefore likely to be older than the British occupation of India. This myth has also been reported by anthropologists working in other parts of Tamil Nadu, and even in Sri Lanka where Paraiyars are also found. One of the most typical versions collected by myself is the following:

Myth 1, version 1: In the beginning, there were two brothers who were poor. Then they went together to pray to God. God asked them to remove the carcass of a dead cow. The elder brother answered: '*Een thambi pappaan*' (My younger brother will do it) but understood: '*Een thambi paappaan*' (My younger brother is a Brahman); since that very day, the younger brother became Brahman (*paappaan*) and the elder brother became a Paraiyar. All castes originate from these two brothers.

This version of the myth contains most of the essential elements. The fact that God plays a role is not significant. In most other versions, a king or a father makes the decision, and in any case Paraiyar informants insist that God did not decide anything but only sanctioned the elder brother's decision. Two points are crucial, however: the fact that the two men were brothers; and the misunderstanding which resulted in the fall of the elder. Note that the Tamil language has no single term for 'brother' but distinguishes between the 'younger' brother (*thambi*) and the 'elder' brother (*annan*). In Tamil society this distinction is crucial, since the elder brother is considered superior to the younger brother and is associated with the father whom he will succeed as head of the family. It can therefore be argued that, according to this myth, the Paraiyar was originally superior to the Brahman. This reading is confirmed by Iyer (1981, vol.1: 69) who mentions that in Kerala the Paraiyar is called the 'elder Brahman', and by Aiyappan who writes that in the same region the very low Nayadis are called 'old sons' (*halle makkalu*) and are mythologically related to the Brahmans (1937: 131-5). Villagers of Valghira Manickam say that the local Brahmans themselves acknowledge this connexion by giving small wedding gifts of betel nuts, fruit and flowers which they call *annanvarisai*, 'the gift to the elder brother'. The neighbouring Pallars, in spite of their constant readiness to denigrate the Paraiyars, also insist that the Brahmans and the Paraiyars were originally brothers. In other words, in the beginning, the Paraiyar was not inferior at all. How then did he lose his prestige? Had he some inherent, natural defect or did he do something very evil?

This brings us to the second important point: the misunderstanding which is the basis of the elder brother's loss of status. This misunderstanding is crucial to the untouchable myth and is present in every version. If untouchables have lost their original relative superiority, it is not because they did something wrong, or because there was something inherently bad about them, but because of a misunderstanding, a trick, a pun, or even because of the crookedness of their brother. In many versions of the myth, the ancestor of the untouchables behaved in an exemplary way, so that, generally speaking, his fall was undeserved and, in some cases, unjust. At worst, the elder brother was rather naive, but this hardly justifies his subsequent downfall. Things might well have gone the other way.

In a more 'sanskritized' version of the myth, God actually thanks the elder brother for his efficiency:

Myth 1, Version 2: Two brothers went to a temple to conduct a ceremony of prayer (*jabbam*). On their way, they found the remains of a dead cow. As the younger brother was weak and tired, the elder proposed to remove the carcass himself. The people present told him that he should rather conduct the prayer session, but he answered: '*Een thambi pappaan*'. These people understood that his younger brother was a Brahman (*paappaan*). To thank him for his work, God blessed him and made him a Paraiyar whereas the younger brother became a Brahman.

In version 2 of the myth, being a Paraiyar is represented as an honour, a privilege granted by God to thank the elder brother. Once again, God merely sanctions the decision of the elder brother who is then asked to become a priest, thus suggesting that there was nothing in his nature which made him a Paraiyar. In other versions it is a king or father who intervenes:

Myth 1, version 3: A man had five sons. He always asked the elder to work for him, to fetch water, etc. But the latter always refused and said: '*Een thambi pappaan*'. The father understood that the younger brother was a Brahman and the elder became the Paraiyar.

There are many more versions of this myth, but it is unnecessary to detail them here. We can perhaps simply quote the myth collected by David in Sri Lanka and reported by Moffatt (1979: 125-6). Although recorded in a different place, it is clearly another version of Myth 1:

Myth 2: Two brothers were the *pusaris* (priests) in a Mariamman temple. The elder brother decided to fast and to observe a vow of silence. He wanted his younger brother to watch over the temple. So he said to the people '*Nan parrayan, tampi parpar*': 'I am the drum person' (*parai* = funeral drum; *ar* = person), 'younger brother is the priest' (*tampi* = younger brother; *parpar*, from *par*, to see = seer, wise one, priest).

There is thus a structure common to the myths described so far: in each of them, the ancestor starts in a situation of equality or even relative superiority (mainly as elder brother) and is associated with positive values (piety, honesty, devotion, willingness, dutifulness, diligence, etc.). The younger brother is rather passive, maybe even dull; as we shall see later, only in one version of the myth, where there are several younger brothers, do they intervene and in this case they are rather wicked, wrongly accusing the elder of theft.

All these versions include a 'reversible factor' which completely changes the situation: this factor is a pun, misunderstanding, trick, joke or deceit. It completely changes the initial situation and the superior suddenly finds himself the inferior.

I want to emphasize that there is nothing inherent in the elder brother's condition which made his loss of status inevitable. If the Paraiyars are poor, suffering and hard-working, it is not because of their deeds in a previous life or because of some congenital defect, but because of a misunderstanding about their mythical ancestor. Consequently, the low status of the Paraiyars as a whole is largely undeserved.

The Paraiyars do not generally believe that they could be reborn as Brahmans or as members of some other caste. Caste (*jaati*) is understood here as a sort of species, and it is neither possible nor desirable to change one's caste (for a similar conception of caste as a 'genus' or 'substance', see Parry 1979: 85-6 and Daniel 1987: 2). For this reason, inter-caste marriages, including those into high castes, are not favoured. Paraiyars thus do not consider it a curse to be born a Paraiyar. If they did, it would be pointless to strive to improve their circumstances; yet the

Paraiyars, like most Indian untouchables, struggle to assert their rights and improve their lot.

Conflicting interpretations

The main features of the interpretation outlined so far are supported by most of the anthropologists who have reported untouchable myths. Kolenda (1964) was probably the first to stress the discrepancy between the philosophical concepts of Hinduism and the beliefs of untouchables. She wrote that the sweepers of Khala-pur, in Uttar Pradesh, do not believe that caste position reflects punishment for deeds in past lives but is 'just a terrible historical accident' (1964: 75). Miller also stressed the place of Mahars outside the Brahmanical system and its traditions (1966: 29). Berreman similarly suggested that untouchables do not consider themselves a degraded social category, but rationalize their low status as the result of bad luck or misfortune (1963: 243):

No informants were found who said in effect, 'I was a scoundrel in a previous life and now I am getting my just deserts'. Neither was any caste found whose members said in effect: 'We have always done defiling work. This was what we were created to do and we do it. Therefore we are untouchable'. These (and particularly the first) seem to be psychologically untenable positions for individuals to accept (1963: 223).

Mosse (1985) reports a version of the Paraiyar myth, collected from the Totti Paraiyars in Suranam village (Ramnad District), which he interprets in a similar way:

Myth 3: There were two Brahman brothers (*annan* and *tampi*). *Annan* went to the temple everyday to conduct *pūja*. A cow came from *intira lokam* (heaven) and after cooking *ponkal* rice and other offerings, *annan* would take one drop of blood from the cow to worship (*irattappali*, blood sacrifice). The cow would then go away. Daily he went to the temple and brought back *ponkal* rice for his wife and younger brother. One day, a rumour was spread and the village told *tampi*: 'your brother is eating beef in the temple and only bringing you rice *piracaatam*'.

Tampi told his brother's pregnant wife and asked her to tell her husband to bring them a little beef next time. When her husband returned she told him: 'You were eating beef, yet I am pregnant and you are only bringing *piracaatam* to me. If you don't give me any beef, I will kill myself. *Annan*, who had in fact never eaten any beef, was worried, thinking a woman's word must be obeyed. He therefore went to the temple and cut a piece of flesh from the cow. The cow died. *Tampi*, seeing what happened, hid and refused to eat beef. Villagers held a *panchayat* and said to *annan*: 'Since you killed the cow, you must take it away and eat it. You are untouchable, you beefeater (*niintintaamai*, *nii maatvettipayal*). Go away from the village'. When leaving the village, *annan* met a man: 'Where are you going, *swamy*?', he said. 'It is my bad time, I am going', *annan* replied. 'If you go, who will look after the temple?' *Annan* replied with the pun: '*Koyil velai tampi paappaan*' (*tampi* will see the temple work or *paappaan* = Brahman).

Annan and his wife arrived in another village. The people gave him a hut and told them to collect cooked rice daily for their food. Then they held a *panchayat* and gave *annan* the job of village watchman (*tankilan*), calling people for meetings. To make his work easier he took some skin from a dead calf and made a *tappu* (or *parai*) drum. From this came the title *paraiyan*. At first people brought him their dead animals but later they made him go and collect dead cows, and they avoided him because of his work (Mosse 1985: 242-4).

Mosse remarks that this interesting version illustrates the fall of untouchables from prosperity and high caste status to a position of poverty and servitude. He bases this interpretation on the views of the people themselves:

High castes, explained one youth leader, obtained land by fraudulent means, and through the generosity of the Pallars who allowed these people to settle in the village (Mosse 1985: 238).

We shall return to this theme of untouchable generosity later, but should note in passing that it is a common form of self-representation which contrasts with external images of an inherent impurity. Mosse thus insists that the loss of status is unintentional, and that it is provoked by men rather than desired by gods (1985: 245). The servitude and poverty of low castes is humanly instituted and is not understood as an inherent attribute of caste (1985: 237). Thus far, Mosse confirms former interpretations of the myth but he also adds an element neglected by other scholars: the Totti Paraiyars, he points out, assert through their myths that they do not deserve to be low and that their inferiority is the result of bad luck (*viiti*), trickery by high castes, and historical accident. At the same time, however, and this should be emphasized here, these myths accept that cattle scavenging, funeral service, drumming and beef eating are indeed filthy, polluting and despicable activities. They refuse to admit that these tasks are an inherent characteristic of their own caste but they recognize that those who do perform them are contemptible (1985: 246).

This critical nuance suggests that untouchable myths do not reject the caste system as such but agree with its ideological foundations. Generally speaking, untouchables have been unable to challenge caste behaviour and its values. What they do contest is their own position in the system. They legitimize untouchability but do not think that they themselves are polluting and degraded. Moffatt has also analysed the Paraiyar myth and has challenged Kolenda's interpretation. Moffatt collected several myths among the Paraiyars of Endavur, and it is useful to quote one version of our main myth from his book (1979: 120-1):

Myth 4: At the origin, there was nothing in the world. There was no life. There was nothing except one woman, Aadi ('origin'). She was all alone and wanted a husband. She made a sacrificial fire and finally a handsome man emerged from the fire. He married her. He was none other than Iswaran (Siva). The couple lived happily.

After some time four children were born to Aadi. The gods were satisfied that everything was complete except for the creation of the castes. So they planned it. According to their plan, the four children, who had become adults, were made to cook beef one day. The eldest son offered to do the cooking. While he was cooking, the other three brothers sat around him, watching him cook. While the meat was boiling, one piece fell from the pot. The eldest son saw it fall on the ground, and thought it would bring a bad name to his cooking. So, meaning well, he hid it under the heap of ash. Immediately the others accused him of theft, and scolded him for stealing a big piece of meat for himself. They shouted at him: '*Paraiyaa, Maraiyaade!*' ('Paraiyan, do not hide (that)'). Hence the name 'Paraiyan'. Eventually the elder brother was forced to live separately, and was called 'Paraiyan'.

This myth, which is also found in other parts of India (see, for instance, Briggs 1953: 51), is different from the myth considered earlier, though its 'structure' remains the same: in both, a reversal from a favourable to a degraded state is brought about by a misunderstanding. Moffatt recognizes that 'the central incident of the myth is important structurally, for it represents an inversion and a code-switch around the features of relative rank' (1979: 123). He also agrees with Kolenda that the myth fulfils a psychological function in offering the Harijans a 'prideful claim to former precedence, despite the present low status' (1979: 123); nevertheless, Moffatt offers an altogether different interpretation of the myth by refusing to accept that the fall is an accident. For Moffatt, the 'Gods had planned for it' (1979: 122); they set up the incident. This point is crucial, for it implies

that caste division is divinely ordained and that God himself wanted the Paraiyars to be inferior because of their own character.

As we have already seen, however, God is not always present in the myths. Even in the version presented by Moffatt, God intervenes only at a preliminary stage, and though he wants to establish the caste system, he does not decree that the elder brother should be inferior. In fact, he later withdraws and allows the people to decide for themselves. This early episode adds little to the core of the myth. It is worth remembering here that in Valghira Manickam, informants always insisted that caste was not divinely instituted but was established by men, or worse by Brahmans (Deliège 1989: 109). This insistence is widely confirmed in other ethnographic contexts: Molund, for instance, reports that the Koris of Kanpur leave no doubt on the matter; as one informant told him:

The caste system is a human thing. If a man gets blind it is because of God (Bhagwan), if he is born into a low caste it is because man has created a society of castes...God has not made it impossible for us to try to improve our situation; as we do not know what awaits us in the future we should at least try to make the best of the situation (1988: 156-7).

In Tamil Nadu, Kapadia found that untouchables consider their 'impurity' to be an 'unfair ascription, imposed on them by the upper castes' (1990: 249) and, as noted above, the Harijans of Suranam also regard caste as a 'humanly instituted order' (Mosse 1985: 256). Similarly, the Pallars of Alangkulam often claimed that it was not God but the Brahmans who invented the caste system for their own ends. Moreover, as already mentioned, notions of Hinduism such as *karma* and *dharma* have generally much less significance for the low than for the high castes (Kolenda 1964: 72; Juergensmeyer 1982: 99; Maloney 1975: 174-5; Freeman 1979: 52). So though God may actually intervene in some versions of the myth, his intervention is not crucial, since he always leaves the people to decide for themselves. He merely acknowledges their decision.

Moffatt also introduces a second element which he sees as fundamental to an interpretation of the myth; according to him, the 'central incident' is due to the stupidity of the Paraiyar. What the myth says, Moffatt argues, relying on the commentaries of the people themselves, is that untouchables are indeed foolish, stupid and unable to see a task through. He cites one old man: 'Even now the same situation continues. We are generally innocent, without any idea of theft and cheating' (Moffatt 1979: 121). Moffatt concludes that people often describe themselves as foolish and naive, 'images in accord with those in the myths' (1979: 128). This foolishness, Moffatt continues, 'results in a curse of the God'. In other words, if the gods reduced the untouchables to their present status, it is because of some intrinsic characteristic of the latter. Moffatt thus disagrees that there is something accidental in the fall and that the whole story is the unfortunate consequence of a mistake or misunderstanding (1979: 122).

Moffatt's position is not always consistent on this matter; on the one hand, he agrees with Kolenda that the myth fulfils a psychological function in providing the untouchables with a claim to former precedence (1979: 123), but at the same time he stresses the fact that the myth shows them to deserve their inferior status because of their stupidity and gullibility (1979: 128). These two elements seem contradictory. Can the untouchables be proud of being foolish? In contrast to Moffatt's interpretation, the attitude of the elder brother could be read as socially positive; he is generous, hardworking, obliging, helpful, responsible, devout,

strong, well-wishing and well-intentioned. There is admittedly some degree of naivety in his behaviour, but this can be seen as a morally positive element, something inherent to goodness in a pitiless world.

To be 'naive' is not the same thing as to be 'foolish'. On the contrary, recent ethnographic reports show that untouchables have positive images of themselves and often depict the higher castes in negative terms. The low-caste representation of the Brahman in Andhra Pradesh is, for instance, one of greediness, ridiculousness, impotency and avarice (Herrenschmidt 1989: 31-6; see also Lynch 1969: 163). In Tamil Nadu, the Pallars view themselves as the 'auspicious providers of agricultural bounty' and believe that a farm will not prosper unless tilled by a Pallar (Kapadia 1990: 118). Harijans often speak of non-Harijans as 'greedy', 'proud' and 'lazy', whereas they see themselves as generous and hardworking (Djurfeldt & Lindberg 1975: 219). This last characteristic is certainly present in several versions of the myth, and the elder brother is sometimes thanked for his willingness to work. In Ramnad, untouchables clearly perceive the dominant caste of Kallars as oppressive, violent, rough and authoritarian. In short, the self-image of untouchables is not wholly negative. Of course, they often stress the difficulties of improving their position, but this recognition is based on experience, rather than a mark of 'fatalism'. It is very difficult for a Harijan to climb the social ladder and one could hardly contradict them on this point.

Moffatt surprisingly fails to emphasize how the untouchable myth implicitly legitimizes a social hierarchy based on the notions of purity and pollution. The myth offers no alternative to the system but merely contests the position of the caste within it. Furthermore, the myth accepts the idea that a breach in the rules of pollution should result in an inferior status, and that ritually impure tasks are socially degrading. The cow and its carcass are central to most versions of the myth which suggests, as Mosse points out, that untouchables basically agree with the ideology of caste. There is no criticism of untouchability as such. Untouchables accept that those below them are rightly regarded as untouchable, and they accept the ideological foundations of untouchability. At the same time, however, they believe that their own caste's degradation is largely unjustified.

While Moffatt's interpretation imperfectly reflects the ideology of untouchables, it does account for how the high castes see them. While the untouchables consider themselves naive, the high castes see them as stupid. As the next section shows, some myths express this high caste view of the untouchables.

Sanskritization and some other untouchable myths

Before examining versions of the myths from other parts of India, it is useful to show how the myths analysed so far are typical of low castes which recognize their inferiority or take it for granted. When a low caste wants to improve its position, it usually begins by adopting a new myth of origin consistent with its ambition. This is part of a process of *sanskritization* through which a low caste changes its customs, ideology, ritual and way of life in keeping with high caste practice (Srinivas 1971: 6). As early as the nineteenth century, the Nadars, a low caste of Tamil Nadu, launched a movement of social emancipation and popularized myths which portrayed themselves as the descendants of seven brothers who were born of celestial virgins and were brought up by the goddess

Bhadrakali; after the river Vaigai flooded, the brothers refused to obey a royal order to build a dam by carrying baskets of earth on their heads. The king beheaded two of the brothers for their disobedience but their heads floated away shouting, 'I shall not carry baskets'. Frightened by this miracle, the king released the remaining five brothers who gave birth to the Nadars who, to this day, never touch a basket (Hardgrave 1969: 19-21). Such a story clearly provides a mythological background to the Nadars' refusal to perform menial and servile duties. Its nature is radically different from the Paraiyar myth. There is no question here of degradation. On the contrary, all the elements express the dignity of the Nadars, from their birth to their heroic resistance to the king, and their refusal to be associated with the labouring classes.

In the 1980s, the Pallars of Tamil Nadu also launched an emancipation movement and they too popularized a new myth:

Myth 5: The original inhabitants of a fertile river valley, who therefore hold the title of Vellalars, were an ancient cultivator and warrior people called Mallars. They worshipped Intiran or Teventiran and were called Teventira Kullar Vellalars. As heads of the village councils, or *kutumpus*, they were also known as Teventira Kutumpan. They were the first to till the land and build the cities of the ancient Tamil civilization. At that time, ancestors of Kallars, Maravars, Akamutayars, etc., were tribal inhabitants of the Palai dry land. Mallars (=Pallars) enjoyed all the rights and honours of royalty. They were the Pandara warriors and were responsible for the Harappa civilization.

However, they were conquered by Muslim and Telugu invaders, in the 17th century, who, seeking to overthrow the original rulers of the land, established the 'jungle tribes' such as Kallars, and Maravars as Palaiyakkars (Poliyars). The Mallars were deprived of their land and reduced to the state of serfs. They were weakened by being scattered and their name was changed into Pallars meaning low and despicable (Mosse 1985: 356).

Myth 5 is quite different from the first myth discussed and has a pseudo-historical character. Not only are the Pallars described as kings, but the currently dominant castes are reduced to the status of 'jungle tribes' and owe their present dominance to the invasion of foreigners and Muslims, a fact which makes them, in a sense, 'collaborators'. This tribal, savage origin also explains why they are presently stereotyped as rough and violent. Pallars, in contrast, were the sophisticated rulers of the Indus civilization.

It is clear that castes which want to express their greatness and 'sanskritize' their way of life adopt new myths. In contrast, the different versions of the Paraiyar myth recognize the present situation rather than challenge it. As such, they are not used to support status claims.

In the village of Kuliyanur (Muthuramalinga Thevar district), the Koonars constitute the dominant caste: they own most of the village land, control village institutions such as the *panchayat* and represent the majority of the village population. Traditionally the status of these goatherds was fairly low, but in the last fifty years or so they have improved their position and 'sanskritized' their way of life (see Rao 1979). The myth which I collected in Kuliyanur expresses this mobility and constitutes a reversal of the Paraiyar myth:

Myth 6: The Koonars were the last of all people. At that time, they were even worse than Pallars. They were kept aside. No one would drink water or eat food from them. One day, Lord Krishna thought: 'Since these people are kept aside, someone should give them importance'. Therefore he went inside the house of a Koonar and took some buttermilk and butter. This was witnessed by all people and then all castes, including Brahmans, started to be friendly, drink buttermilk and water from Koonars.

Since the story continues by recounting how Siva and Parvati also gave powers to the caste, villagers claim that this myth shows how they had been blessed by the gods. The interesting aspect of the myth is how a previously inferior status is transformed into a much higher one as a result of the protection of the gods.

These Nadar, Pallar and Koonar myths greatly differ from each other, and I present them here only to show how the myths of socially mobile castes differ from the untouchable myths discussed earlier.

In the Koonar myth, God's blessing is the crucial factor of the transformation and is what permits the sanskritization of the caste. God's blessing is often present in South Indian mythology and is central to a myth common among the Valaiyars which I collected in Alangkulam village. Although the Valaiyars are not a 'Scheduled Caste', they are a very low caste indeed and their myth clearly expresses a low caste status. It thus seems justifiable to include them here. The Valaiyars are hunters and they catch small game with their nets (*valai*, hence their caste name):

Myth 7: Lord Iswaran was giving his blessing (*aaseervatham*) to all people and distributed sacred ashes (*thinuneeru*). The Koonars came up with a big pot and thus a lot of ashes fell into the pot; they were very blessed and that is why today many people among them are well off. Other people came with their hands and they were also blessed; today they are also well off.

The Valaiyars were fool enough to come with a *valai* (net) and thus when Iswaran gave the ashes most of it fell on the ground. Only a few particles remained on the knots of the *valai* and the Valaiyars were little blessed.

Those who told me this myth interpreted it in a way which partly supports Moffatt's interpretation. They said that it explains why the Valaiyars have always remained poor – because they were unable to use God's blessings. It was not Siva who made them poor, but because they were stupid enough to try to collect ashes with their net. Their explanation lies somewhere between Moffatt's and the one presented above. On the one hand, God wished them well, but on the other hand, the Valaiyars turned out to be fools. In other words, the curse which fell upon them was a result of their own inherent stupidity.

Djurfeldt and Lindberg report that the Paraiyars in a village 35 kilometres south of Madras city have a myth which closely resembles that of the Valaiyars:

Myth 8: Once upon a time, a group of people belonging to different castes were out fishing in a tank. Among them was a Harijan. While they were fishing, Isvaran, i.e. Siva, suddenly appeared before them. He promised each of them a gift. But before they would get it, they were all asked to put on a sacred thread. So they did.

Our Harijan was fishing with an *ottu* that day. An *ottu* is a coneshaped basket, open at both ends...When they had put on the thread, God asked them all to line up and receive the gift. They all got their gifts and wrapped them up in pieces of cloth and carried them safely away, except our foolish Paraiya who held out his *ottu* forgetting that it was open at both ends.

When home he looked in his *ottu* for the gift God had given him but to his grief he found it empty. He felt very sad and brooded over his bad luck.

That is how our Paraiya lost his gift from God. And even today the saying has it that: '*ottuvile vanginadu, suttal vittam*' i.e. an *ottu* is like a human body, mouth at one end and anus at the other. Our Paraiya received his gift from God through the mouth of the *ottu* and lost it through the bottom of it (Djurfeldt & Lindberg 1975: 222-3).

This myth is clearly a version of the Valaiyar myth in depicting the untouchables as rather stupid. The man who reported this version to the ethnographers stressed the 'badness' of Harijans (1975: 224). Yet, at the same time, the myth also

corresponds to what Moffatt calls an '*uur*', or high caste version of untouchable status. Moreover, the crucial role which God plays in it shows a certain degree of 'sanskritization'. The high caste myths reported by Moffatt systematically emphasize the stupidity of the untouchable ancestors and give God a prominent place in the story (see Moffatt 1979: 125, 126-7). These versions are sometimes reported by untouchables themselves, especially when they live in a high caste village and know of no other myth, but they are not typical of untouchable ideology which, as Djurfeldt and Lindberg themselves point out (1975: 219), provides a positive self-image. High caste people systematically describe untouchables as foolish, dirty, stupid, savage, lazy, irreligious and unsophisticated. The Valaiyar myth exploits some of these themes but untouchables rarely hold such degraded images of themselves. On the contrary, it is the Brahmans whom they see as lazy and crooked, and Moffatt himself reports their delight in telling stories of high caste trickery or beef-eating. Moreover, untouchables value physical strength while high castes do not. Moffatt remarks that physical strength is not highly prized in 'Tamil culture' (1979: 119), although he should have qualified this by adding in 'Tamil *brahmanical* culture' for as he himself reports, the Harijans of Tamil Nadu do value it. There is thus some degree of discordance between untouchable and high caste culture, and the myths of origin are an illustration of this disjunction.

Myths from other regions

As suggested above, the Paraiyar myth is but one local version of a more general untouchable myth. Similar stories are told by untouchables from very distant regions, a clear example of which is provided by the Chamars of North India who have a myth very similar to the untouchable myths discussed so far:

Myth 9: In the beginning, there was one family of men and they were all of the highest caste. They worked in the fields. In this family, there were four brothers. It happened that a cow died one day and the body lay in the garden until evening. Since no one could be found to remove the carcass, the three older brothers agreed that their younger brother should carry away the body from the yard and that they would all take a bath on the same footing of equality. To this the younger brother agreed and he dragged the carcass into the jungle. After the bath, the brothers compelled him to remain at a distance. They told him that henceforth he would do the work of a Chamar and that they would take care of him for his services. Thus the Chamar caste arose (Briggs 1920: 15-6).

The similarity between this and the Paraiyar myth is striking. The main difference is that the hero in Myth 9 is the younger brother and the relative superiority is less pronounced, but the equality of all people is clearly asserted. Most of the other ingredients of the myth are also present: the original group of brothers, the dead cow, the collective decision, the non-intervention of God, and the trickery; the younger brother is cheated, since he is promised a purificatory bath like the other brothers, but is later reduced to an inferior position.

The Bhangis, the sweepers of North India, stress the trickery of the brothers in an even more explicit way:

Myth 10: When the Pandus were starting out for the Himalayas, after the great war, one of their cows died and they did not know how to dispose of the carcass, as it was a sin to touch it. The four brothers conspired against Nakula and asked him to remove it: 'Good lad, remove the carcass and we promise not to excommunicate you.' He hid the carcass under some leaves near a tree. But on his return, his brothers refused to receive him unless he brought mango

wood for the performance of the *hom* or fire sacrifice. While he was away fetching the wood, they deserted him. Afterwards he returned to the cow and wept. When Po! by the grace of the Almighty, the cow was returned to life. Nakula grew up on the milk of the cow. Later on the cow died and while he was lamenting a voice from heaven said: 'Do not grieve! You Balmik are destined to be the progenitors of those who make fans and sieves from the hides of the cow. These you will sell and you will teach the world the act of grinding and sifting flour for bread'. Nakula became an ascetic and taught the art of making bread (Briggs 1953: 64).

In this myth, God supports the mythical ancestor and makes him humanity's 'breadgiver'. The ancestor later becomes an ascetic which, in untouchable ideology, represents the hope for egalitarian idealism and is a living example of divinity (Khare 1984: 22, 27). At the same time, the events described in the myth occur when it is already a sin to handle dead animals, particularly the cow. In contrast, other myths explicitly trace the origin of this taboo, as with a version from the Mahars of Maharashtra (see Briggs 1953: 61):

Myth 11: Before beef had become a prohibited food, Mahamuni was left to watch a pot of meat cooking. None other than the divine cow Tripad Gayatri was in the stew. When a piece of flesh fell out, Mahamuni, rather than return it to the pot, ate it. Discovered in his delinquency by the gods, he was penalized by being required, along with his descendants, to eat the flesh of dead cows.

Unlike other versions, God has a more prominent role in Myth 11. However, here too the hero has been cheated. If the meat was cooking, it was no doubt to be eaten! Yet when Mahamuni eats a piece, he is immediately treated as a 'delinquent' and punished accordingly. The prohibition on eating beef seems to have been deliberately created in order to harm the untouchables.

Versions of this myth of several brothers handling a cow's carcass are found in many places. It is known to the Doms in the Punjab (Briggs 1953: 53) and to the Chamars of Senapur who relate a myth very similar to Myth 10 (Cohn 1954: 113):

Myth 12: Once four Brahmin brothers were going to a fair. On their way, they had to cross a river, but as they came to the river, they saw a cow stuck in the mud by the bank. One by one, they tried to extricate the cow from the mud. As the younger brother was pulling on the tail of the cow trying to get it out, the cow died. As the younger brother was touching the cow when it died, his other brothers considered him to be unclean and had nothing to do with him from then on. The present day Camars (*sic*) are descendants of this outcasted Brahmin.

Each version differs to some extent but all share certain basic elements: the fall of the untouchables is the result of a trick or misunderstanding; the beginning of time is characterized by equality and the destitution of the caste is not due to some inherent defect; and a hierarchy based on ritual pollution is legitimized. At the same time, however, each version contests the justice of degrading the hero's whole caste.

This ambiguity in untouchable ideology has already been identified by Cohn (1954: 262):

It should be realized that, although the Camars attack the superior social position of the Thakurs and are actively trying to raise their own status, they are not consciously trying to eliminate the caste system. No one in the village is interested in destroying the caste system. The Camars are solely interested in raising their status in the system.

The myths described here clearly express this ambiguity. Untouchables have not absorbed all the values of the caste system (see Deliège 1992), but have developed a world-view which does not always fit with the dominant culture

(Vincentnathan 1987: 69). Nevertheless, they have not developed a 'counter-culture', and have generally tried to improve their position within the system itself rather than replace it altogether. As such, the myths discussed here do not provide 'models for action', nor even challenge untouchability, but they do make status mobility ideologically possible and ethically acceptable. Even the most traditional untouchables do not believe that their position is God-given, or that it would be sinful to try to change it. On the contrary, seeing their ancestor as generous, pious, hardworking and honest helps to reassure them that any attempt to improve their status is justified. This conclusion is largely supported by the comments of contemporary Indians and fits well with the many emancipation movements found among untouchables.

Conclusion

The myths of origin discussed in this article should suffice to show a high degree of consistency in the ideology of untouchables. There is no *complete* disjunction between the untouchable ideology and higher caste views. Generally speaking, the low castes have no alternative to caste ideology and have nothing with which to oppose caste society. Their myths take caste for granted, and by stressing their brotherhood with Brahmins, they acknowledge the superiority of the latter. They also assume that caste groups share a common substance, and that the behaviour of one individual affects the whole group. Yet untouchables do not think that their position in the system is immutable and imposed by God. The myths make it quite clear that social change is possible.

At the same time, we have also seen that the myths are not essential elements of contemporary untouchability and sometimes they are no longer even known. The Pallars of Alankulam, for example, knew no stories about their caste origins, nor had the Helas of Allahabad any mythological explanation for their low position (Houska 1981: 83). Even in Valghira Manickam, it is clear that the myth has mainly historical value. In the absence of textual sources on Harijan ideology, myths and other sources of oral tradition can be taken as evidence about the past (see Vansina 1985), or in this case about what untouchables thought in the past. Other sources of oral tradition, such as Paraiyar songs, seem to support the idea that untouchables do not believe their position is deserved (see Trawick 1987).

If the myths described here are less frequently told today, it is not only because people are now more interested in popular film music than in their own tradition, as Houska (1981) has argued, but also because these myths have lost much of their significance. Under the influence of democratic ideas, untouchables hold stronger views than before about the unfairness of their position and they wish to change it. They are more concerned with basic issues of survival than with questions of ritual impurity. Besides, in many parts of India untouchables have long given up carrying out degrading tasks for higher castes. This shift, however, does not mean that the practice of untouchability has now disappeared or even that it has sharply declined in contemporary India. The gap between untouchables and the rest of the population is as great as it ever was, and the privileges granted to untouchables by the Indian Constitution have helped to stigmatize

them and mark them off from the rest of the population to such an extent that these privileges have arguably reinforced untouchability. However, if untouchability clearly persists, it is now less often expressed in a language of ritual purity. It is rather naïve to reduce untouchability to a mere problem of ritual pollution, as Dumont tends to do. The impurity of the untouchable may be conceptually linked to the purity of the Brahman but, in practice, untouchability is little affected by the devaluation of Brahman purity as Dumont believed (1966: 77). In Tamil Nadu and elsewhere, for instance, the non-Brahman movement has considerably weakened the status of Brahmans without dramatically improving that of untouchables.

The untouchables themselves are perfectly aware of this and the question of their ritual status is no longer perceived by them as critical. Parry (1970) and Mines (1984) have illustrated the switch from traditional values to more political and economic matters: among the Kolis of North India, for instance, the younger generation contradicted the status claims of their elders in order to be officially recognized as 'Backward Castes' and thereby take advantage of the government system of positive discrimination. This is probably true of the younger generation throughout India. It can thus be said that while caste and untouchability are still very much alive in contemporary India, the question of ritual status has become increasingly irrelevant. That is probably why the myths discussed here are less popular today than they once were; they are concerned with rather old-fashioned issues and fail to promote the social changes which the untouchables now desire.

The Pallar myth reported by Mosse (see Myth 5 above) exemplifies the more aggressive and militant attitudes of younger 'Dalits' ('the exploited'), as some untouchables now refer to themselves. Yet these more recent myths share something with the older and more conservative myths outlined here: they do not question the foundations of caste. The Pallar myth not only fails to deny the reality of caste but to some extent reifies it by glorifying the caste's past. In both types of myth, the inability of untouchables to overcome caste is obvious. This is probably another curse which falls upon untouchables: they are unable to contest the barriers of caste, even less to break them. The only great leader they have produced, B.R. Ambedkar, was himself unable to win the votes of untouchables who did not belong to his own caste (Zelliot 1970: 59), and untouchables today remain hopelessly divided along caste lines.

I have noted that to some extent untouchable myths contradict the basic concepts of Hinduism. Yet we have seen how these same myths also uphold caste as an institution. Such ambiguity is undoubtedly a striking example of the insidiousness of caste notions, even among the system's most obvious victims.

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Les mythes d'origine des intouchables indiens

Résumé

L'idéologie des intouchables contemporains est très certainement influencée par les changements démocratiques de la société indienne. La question de savoir si, dans le passé, les intouchables étaient plus proches de l'orthodoxie hindoue et si, comme le pensait Weber, ils se référaient aux concepts religieux de l'hindouisme pour légitimer leur infériorité sociale, est, par contre, beaucoup moins claire. Les mythes d'origine, dont le caractère ancien est incontestable, peuvent alors nous éclairer sur l'image que les intouchables ont – et avaient – d'eux-mêmes et de leur position dans la société. Ces mythes d'origine, qui se retrouvent parmi les intouchables de toute l'Inde, affirment que les intouchables étaient originellement des gens respectables et que la condition dégradée qui est la leur aujourd'hui est le fruit d'une erreur et non la conséquence d'une déficience intrinsèque. Ces mythes contestent donc la position des intouchables au sein du système des castes, sans toutefois s'attaquer à ce système lui-même dont ils cautionnent les fondements. Cette ambiguïté est caractéristique de la position des intouchables dans la société indienne en général.

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